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1 James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, To the twelve tribes of the Dispersion: Greetings.

[2] Consider it pure joy, my brothers, when you encounter trials of many kinds, [3] because you know that the testing of your faith develops perseverance. [4] Allow perseverance to finish its work, so that you may be mature and complete, not lacking anything. [5] Now if any of you lacks wisdom, he should ask God, who gives generously to all without finding fault, and it will be given to him. [6] But he must ask in faith, without doubting, because he who doubts is like a wave of the sea, blown and tossed by the wind. [7] That man should not expect to receive anything from the Lord. [8] He is a double-minded man, unstable in all his ways.

[9] The brother in humble circumstances should exult in his high position. [10] But the one who is rich should exult in his low position, because he will pass away like a flower of the field. [11] For the sun rises with scorching heat and withers the plant; its flower falls and its beauty is lost. So too, the rich man will fade away in the midst of his pursuits.

[12] Blessed is the man who perseveres under trial, because when he has stood the test, he will receive the crown of life that God has promised to those who love Him. [13] When tempted, no one should say, "God is tempting me." For God cannot be tempted by evil, nor does He tempt anyone. [14] But each one is tempted when by his own evil desires he is lured away and enticed. [15] Then after desire has conceived, it gives birth to sin; and sin, when it is full-grown, gives birth to death. [16] Do not be deceived, my beloved brothers. [17] Every good and perfect gift is from above, coming down from the Father of the heavenly lights, with whom there is no change or shifting shadow.

[18] He chose to give us birth through the word of truth, that we would be a kind of firstfruits of His creation.

[19] My beloved brothers, understand this: Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger, [20] for man's anger does not bring about the righteousness that God desires. [21] Therefore, get rid of all moral filth and every expression of evil, and humbly accept the word planted in you, which can save your souls. [22] Be doers of the word, and not hearers only. Otherwise, you are deceiving yourselves. [23] For anyone who hears the word but does not carry it out is like a man who looks at his face in a mirror, [24] and after observing himself goes away and immediately forgets what he looks like. [25] But the one who looks intently into the perfect law of freedom, and continues to do so—not being a forgetful hearer, but an effective doer—he will be blessed in what he does. [26] If anyone considers himself religious and yet does not bridle his tongue, he deceives his heart and his religion is worthless. [27] Pure and undefiled religion before our God and Father is this: to care for orphans and widows in their distress, and to keep oneself from being polluted by the world.

2 My brothers, as you hold out your faith in our glorious Lord Jesus Christ, do not show favoritism. [2] Suppose a man comes into your meeting wearing a gold ring and fine clothes, and a poor man in shabby clothes also comes in. [3] If you lavish attention on the man in fine clothes and say, "Here is a seat of honor," but say to the poor man, "You must stand" or "Sit at my feet," [4] have you not discriminated among yourselves and become judges with evil thoughts? [5] Listen, my beloved brothers: Has not God chosen the poor of this world to be rich in faith and to inherit the kingdom He promised those who love Him? [6] But you have dishonored the poor. Is it not the rich who oppress you and drag you into court? [7] Are they not the ones who blaspheme the noble name by which you have been called?

[8] If you really fulfill the royal law stated in Scripture, "Love your neighbor as yourself," you are doing well. [9] But if you show favoritism, you sin and are convicted by the law as transgressors. [10] Whoever keeps the whole law but stumbles at just one point is guilty of breaking all of it. [11] For He who said, "Do not commit adultery," also said, "Do not murder." If you do not commit adultery, but do commit murder, you have become a lawbreaker.

[12] Speak and act as those who are going to be judged by the law that gives freedom. [13] For judgment without mercy will be shown to anyone who has not been merciful. Mercy triumphs over judgment. [14] What good is it, my brothers, if someone claims to have faith, but has no deeds? Can such faith save him? [15] Suppose a brother or sister is without clothes and daily food. [16] If one of you tells him, "Go in peace; stay warm and well fed," but does not provide for his physical needs, what good is that?

[17] So too, faith by itself, if it does not result in action, is dead. [18] But someone will say, "You have faith and I have deeds." Show me your faith without deeds, and I will show you my faith by my deeds. [19] You believe that God is one. Good for you! Even the demons believe that—and shudder. [20] O foolish man, do you want evidence that faith without deeds is worthless? [21] Was not our father Abraham justified by what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? [22] You see that his faith was working with his actions, and his faith was perfected by what he did. [23] And the Scripture was fulfilled that says, "Abraham believed God, and it was credited to him as righteousness," and he was called a friend of God. [24] As you can see, a man is justified by his deeds and not by faith alone. [25] In the same way, was not even Rahab the prostitute justified by her actions when she welcomed the spies and sent them off on another route? [26] As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead.

3 Not many of you should become teachers, my brothers, because you know that we who teach will be judged more strictly. [2] We all stumble in many ways. If anyone is never at fault in what he says, he is a perfect man, able to control his whole body. [3] When we put bits into the mouths of horses to make them obey us, we can guide the whole animal. [4] Consider ships as well. Although they are so large and are driven by strong winds, they are steered by a very small rudder wherever the pilot is inclined. [5] In the same way, the tongue is a small part of the body, but it boasts of great things. Consider how small a spark sets a great forest ablaze. [6] The tongue also is a fire, a world of wickedness among the parts of the body. It pollutes the whole person, sets the course of his life on fire, and is itself set on fire by hell. [7] All kinds of animals, birds, reptiles, and creatures of the sea are being tamed and have been tamed by man, [8] but no man can tame the tongue. It is a restless evil, full of deadly poison. [9] With the tongue we bless our Lord and Father, and with it we curse men, who have been made in God's likeness. [10] Out of the same mouth come blessing and cursing. My brothers, this should not be! [11] Can both fresh water and salt water flow from the same spring? [12] My brothers, can a fig tree grow olives, or a grapevine bear figs? Neither can a salt spring produce fresh water. [13] Who is wise and understanding among you? Let him show it by his good conduct, by deeds done in the humility that comes from wisdom.

[14] But if you harbor bitter jealousy and selfish ambition in your hearts, do not boast in it or deny the truth. [15] Such wisdom does not come from above, but is earthly, unspiritual, demonic. [16] For where jealousy and selfish ambition exist, there will be disorder and every evil practice. [17] But the wisdom from above is first of all pure, then peace-loving, gentle, accommodating, full of mercy and good fruit, impartial, and sincere. [18] Peacemakers who sow in peace reap the fruit of righteousness.

4 What causes conflicts and quarrels among you? Don't they come from the passions at war within you? [2] You crave what you do not have; you kill and covet, but are unable to obtain it. You quarrel and fight. You do not have, because you do not ask. [3] And when you do ask, you do not receive, because you ask with wrong motives, that you may squander it on your pleasures. [4] You adulteresses! Do you not know that friendship with the world is hostility toward God? Therefore, whoever chooses to be a friend of the world renders himself an enemy of God. [5] Or do you think the Scripture says without reason that the Spirit He caused to dwell in us yearns with envy? [6] But He gives us more grace. This is why it says: "God opposes the proud, but gives grace to the humble." [7] Submit yourselves, then, to God. Resist the devil, and he will flee from you.

[8] Draw near to God, and He will draw near to you. Cleanse your hands, you sinners, and purify your hearts, you double-minded. [9] Grieve, mourn, and weep. Turn your laughter to mourning, and your joy to gloom. [10] Humble yourselves before the Lord, and He will exalt you. [11] Brothers, do not slander one another. Anyone who speaks against his brother or judges him speaks against the law and judges it. And if you judge the law, you are not a practitioner of the law, but a judge of it. [12] There is only one Lawgiver and Judge, the One who is able to save and destroy. But who are you to judge your neighbor? [13] Come now, you who say, "Today or tomorrow we will go to this or that city, spend a year there, carry on business, and make a profit." [14] You do not even know what will happen tomorrow! What is your life? You are a mist that appears for a little while and then vanishes. [15] Instead, you ought to say, "If the Lord is willing, we will live and do this or that." [16] As it is, you boast in your proud intentions. All such boasting is evil. [17] Anyone, then, who knows the right thing to do, yet fails to do it, is guilty of sin.

5 Come now, you who are rich, weep and wail over the misery to come upon you. [2] Your riches have rotted and moths have eaten your clothes. [3] Your gold and silver are corroded. Their corrosion will testify against you and consume your flesh like fire. You have hoarded treasure in the last days. [4] Look, the wages you withheld from the workmen who mowed your fields are crying out against you. The cries of the harvesters have reached the ears of the Lord of Hosts. [5] You have lived on earth in luxury and self-indulgence. You have fattened your hearts in the day of slaughter. [6] You have condemned and murdered the righteous, who did not resist you. [7] Be patient, then, brothers, until the Lord's coming. See how the farmer awaits the precious fruit of the soil—how patient he is for the fall and spring rains. [8] You, too, be patient and strengthen your hearts, because the Lord's coming is near. [9] Do not complain about one another, brothers, so that you will not be judged. Look, the Judge is standing at the door! [10] Brothers, as an example of patience in affliction, take the prophets who spoke in the name of the Lord.

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[11] See how blessed we consider those who have persevered. You have heard of Job's perseverance and have seen the outcome from the Lord. The Lord is full of compassion and mercy. [12] Above all, my brothers, do not swear, not by heaven or earth or by any other oath. Simply let your "Yes" be yes, and your "No," no, so that you will not fall under judgment. [13] Is any one of you suffering? He should pray. Is anyone cheerful? He should sing praises. [14] Is any one of you sick? He should call the elders of the church to pray over him and anoint him with oil in the name of the Lord. [15] And the prayer offered in faith will restore the one who is sick. The Lord will raise him up. If he has sinned, he will be forgiven. [16] Therefore confess your sins to each other and pray for each other so that you may be healed. The prayer of a righteous man has great power to prevail. [17] Elijah was a man just like us. He prayed earnestly that it would not rain, and it did not rain on the land for three and a half years. [18] Again he prayed, and the heavens gave rain, and the earth yielded its crops. [19] My brothers, if one of you should wander from the truth and someone should bring him back, [20] consider this: Whoever turns a sinner from the error of his way will save his soul from death and cover over a multitude of sins.

1 Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, To the elect who are exiles of the Dispersion throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia, chosen [2] according to the foreknowledge of God the Father and sanctified by the Spirit for obedience to Jesus Christ and sprinkling by His blood: Grace and peace be yours in abundance.

[3] Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ! By His great mercy He has given us new birth into a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, [4] and into an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, reserved in heaven for you, [5] who through faith are shielded by God's power for the salvation that is ready to be revealed in the last time. [6] In this you greatly rejoice, though now for a little while you may have had to suffer grief in various trials [7] so that the proven character of your faith—more precious than gold, which perishes even though refined by fire—may result in praise, glory, and honor at the revelation of Jesus Christ.

[8] Though you have not seen Him, you love Him; and though you do not see Him now, you believe in Him and rejoice with an inexpressible and glorious joy, [9] now that you are receiving the goal of your faith, the salvation of your souls.

[10] Concerning this salvation, the prophets who foretold the grace to come to you searched and investigated carefully, [11] trying to determine the time and setting to which the Spirit of Christ in them was pointing when He predicted the sufferings of Christ and the glories to follow. [12] It was revealed to them that they were not serving themselves, but you, when they foretold the things now announced by those who preached the gospel to you by the Holy Spirit sent from heaven. Even angels long to look into these things.

[13] Therefore prepare your minds for action. Be sober-minded. Set your hope fully on the grace to be given you at the revelation of Jesus Christ. [14] As obedient children, do not conform to the passions of your former ignorance. [15] But just as He who called you is holy, so be holy in all you do, [16] for it is written: "Be holy, because I am holy." [17] Since you call on a Father who judges each one's work impartially, conduct yourselves in reverent fear during your stay as foreigners. [18] For you know that it was not with perishable things such as silver or gold that you were redeemed from the empty way of life you inherited from your forefathers, [19] but with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot. [20] He was known before the foundation of the world, but was revealed in the last times for your sake. [21] Through Him you believe in God, who raised Him from the dead and glorified Him; and so your faith and hope are in God. [22] Since you have purified your souls by obedience to the truth so that you have a genuine love for your brothers, love one another deeply, from a pure heart. [23] For you have been born again, not of perishable seed, but of imperishable, through the living and enduring word of God. [24] For, "All flesh is like grass, and all its glory like the flowers of the field; the grass withers and the flowers fall," [25] "but the word of the Lord stands forever." And this is the word that was proclaimed to you.

2 Rid yourselves, therefore, of all malice, deceit, hypocrisy, envy, and slander. [2] Like newborn babies, crave pure spiritual milk, so that by it you may grow up in your salvation, [3] now that you have tasted that the Lord is good. [4] As you come to Him, the living stone, rejected by men but chosen and precious in God's sight, [5] you also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house to be a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ. [6] For it stands in Scripture: "See, I lay in Zion a stone, a chosen and precious cornerstone; and the one who believes in Him will never be put to shame." [7] To you who believe, then, this stone is precious. But to those who do not believe, "The stone the builders rejected has become the cornerstone," [8] and, "A stone of stumbling and a rock of offense." They stumble because they disobey the word—and to this they were appointed. [9] But you are a chosen people, a royal priesthood, a holy nation, a people for God's own possession, to proclaim the virtues of Him who called you out of darkness into His marvelous light. [10] Once you were not a people, but now you are the people of God; once you had not received mercy, but now you have received mercy. [11] Beloved, I urge you, as foreigners and exiles, to abstain from the desires of the flesh, which war against your soul. [12] Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us.

[13] Submit yourselves for the Lord's sake to every human institution, whether to the king as the supreme authority, [14] or to governors as those sent by him to punish those who do wrong and to praise those who do right. [15] For it is God's will that by doing good you should silence the ignorance of foolish men.

[16] Live in freedom, but do not use your freedom as a cover-up for evil; live as servants of God. [17] Treat everyone with high regard: Love the brotherhood of believers, fear God, honor the king. [18] Servants, submit yourselves to your masters with all respect, not only to those who are good and gentle, but even to those who are unreasonable. [19] For if anyone endures the pain of unjust suffering because he is conscious of God, this is to be commended. [20] How is it to your credit if you are beaten for doing wrong and you endure it? But if you suffer for doing good and you endure it, this is commendable before God. [21] For to this you were called, because Christ also suffered for you, leaving you an example, that you should follow in His footsteps: [22] "He committed no sin, and no deceit was found in His mouth." [23] When they heaped abuse on Him, He did not retaliate; when He suffered, He made no threats, but entrusted Himself to Him who judges justly. [24] He Himself bore our sins in His body on the tree, so that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. "By His stripes you are healed." [25] For "you were like sheep going astray," but now you have returned to the Shepherd and Overseer of your souls.

3 Wives, in the same way, submit yourselves to your husbands, so that even if they refuse to believe the word, they will be won over without words by the behavior of their wives [2] when they see your pure and reverent demeanor. [3] Your beauty should not come from outward adornment, such as braided hair or gold jewelry or fine clothes, [4] but from the inner disposition of your heart, the unfading beauty of a gentle and quiet spirit, which is precious in God's sight. [5] For this is how the holy women of the past adorned themselves. They put their hope in God and were submissive to their husbands, [6] just as Sarah obeyed Abraham and called him lord. And you are her children if you do what is right and refuse to give way to fear.

[7] Husbands, in the same way, treat your wives with consideration as a delicate vessel, and with honor as fellow heirs of the gracious gift of life, so that your prayers will not be hindered. [8] Finally, all of you, be like-minded and sympathetic, love as brothers, be tenderhearted and humble. [9] Do not repay evil with evil or insult with insult, but with blessing, because to this you were called so that you may inherit a blessing.

[10] For, "Whoever would love life and see good days must keep his tongue from evil and his lips from deceitful speech." [11] He must turn from evil and do good; he must seek peace and pursue it. [12] "For the eyes of the Lord are on the righteous, and His ears are inclined to their prayer. But the face of the Lord is against those who do evil." [13] Who can harm you if you are zealous for what is good?

[14] But even if you should suffer for what is right, you are blessed. "Do not fear what they fear; do not be shaken." [15] But in your hearts sanctify Christ as Lord. Always be prepared to give a defense to everyone who asks you the reason for the hope that is in you. But respond with gentleness and respect, [16] keeping a clear conscience, so that those who slander you may be put to shame by your good behavior in Christ. [17] For it is better, if it is God's will, to suffer for doing good than for doing evil. [18] For Christ also suffered for sins once for all, the righteous for the unrighteous, to bring you to God. He was put to death in the body but made alive in the Spirit, [19] in whom He also went and preached to the spirits in prison [20] who disobeyed long ago when God waited patiently in the days of Noah while the ark was being built. In the ark a few people, only eight souls, were saved through water. [21] And this water symbolizes the baptism that now saves you also—not the removal of dirt from the body, but the pledge of a clear conscience toward God—through the resurrection of Jesus Christ, [22] who has gone into heaven and is at the right hand of God, with angels, authorities, and powers subject to Him.

4 Therefore, since Christ suffered in His body, arm yourselves with the same resolve, because anyone who has suffered in his body is done with sin. [2] Consequently, he does not live out his remaining time on earth for human passions, but for the will of God. [3] For you have spent enough time in the past carrying out the same desires as the Gentiles: living in debauchery, lust, drunkenness, orgies, carousing, and detestable idolatry. [4] Because of this, they consider it strange of you not to plunge with them into the same flood of reckless indiscretion, and they heap abuse on you. [5] But they will have to give an account to Him who is ready to judge the living and the dead. [6] That is why the gospel was preached even to those who are now dead, so that they might be judged as men in the flesh, but live according to God in the spirit. [7] The end of all things is near.

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Therefore be clear-minded and sober, so that you can pray. [8] Above all, love one another deeply, because love covers over a multitude of sins. [9] Show hospitality to one another without complaining. [10] As good stewards of the manifold grace of God, each of you should use whatever gift he has received to serve one another. [11] If anyone speaks, he should speak as one conveying the words of God. If anyone serves, he should serve with the strength God provides, so that in all things God may be glorified through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory and the power forever and ever. Amen. [12] Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial that has come upon you, as though something strange were happening to you. [13] But rejoice that you share in the sufferings of Christ, so that you may be overjoyed at the revelation of His glory. [14] If you are insulted for the name of Christ, you are blessed, because the Spirit of glory and of God rests on you.

[15] Indeed, none of you should suffer as a murderer or thief or wrongdoer, or even as a meddler. [16] But if you suffer as a Christian, do not be ashamed, but glorify God that you bear that name. [17] For it is time for judgment to begin with the family of God; and if it begins with us, what will the outcome be for those who disobey the gospel of God? [18] And, "If it is hard for the righteous to be saved, what will become of the ungodly and the sinner?" [19] So then, those who suffer according to God's will should entrust their souls to their faithful Creator and continue to do good.

5 As a fellow elder, a witness of Christ's sufferings, and a partaker of the glory to be revealed, I appeal to the elders among you: [2] Be shepherds of God's flock that is among you, watching over them not out of compulsion, but because it is God's will; not out of greed, but out of eagerness; [3] not lording it over those entrusted to you, but being examples to the flock. [4] And when the Chief Shepherd appears, you will receive the crown of glory that will never fade away. [5] Young men, in the same way, submit yourselves to your elders. And all of you, clothe yourselves with humility toward one another, because, "God opposes the proud, but gives grace to the humble." [6] Humble yourselves, therefore, under God's mighty hand, so that in due time He may exalt you. [7] Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you. [8] Be sober-minded and alert. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. [9] Resist him, standing firm in your faith and in the knowledge that your brothers throughout the world are undergoing the same kinds of suffering. [10] And after you have suffered for a little while, the God of all grace, who has called you to His eternal glory in Christ, will Himself restore you, secure you, strengthen you, and establish you. [11] To Him be the power forever and ever. Amen. [12] Through Silvanus, whom I regard as a faithful brother, I have written to you briefly, encouraging you and testifying that this is the true grace of God. Stand firm in it. [13] The church in Babylon, chosen together with you, sends you greetings, as does my son Mark. [14] Greet one another with a kiss of love. Peace to all of you who are in Christ.

1 Simon Peter, a servant and apostle of Jesus Christ, To those who through the righteousness of our God and Savior Jesus Christ have received a faith as precious as ours: [2] Grace and peace be multiplied to you through the knowledge of God and of Jesus our Lord.

[3] His divine power has given us everything we need for life and godliness through the knowledge of Him who called us by His own glory and excellence. [4] Through these He has given us His precious and magnificent promises, so that through them you may become partakers of the divine nature, now that you have escaped the corruption in the world caused by evil desires. [5] For this very reason, make every effort to add to your faith virtue; and to virtue, knowledge; [6] and to knowledge, self-control; and to self-control, perseverance; and to perseverance, godliness; [7] and to godliness, brotherly kindness; and to brotherly kindness, love. [8] For if you possess these qualities and continue to grow in them, they will keep you from being ineffective and unproductive in your knowledge of our Lord Jesus Christ. [9] But whoever lacks these traits is nearsighted to the point of blindness, having forgotten that he has been cleansed from his past sins. [10] Therefore, brothers, strive to make your calling and election sure. For if you practice these things you will never stumble, [11] and you will receive a lavish reception into the eternal kingdom of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ.

[12] Therefore I will always remind you of these things, even though you know them and are established in the truth you now have. [13] I think it is right to refresh your memory as long as I live in the tent of my body, [14] because I know that this tent will soon be laid aside, as our Lord Jesus Christ has made clear to me. [15] And I will make every effort to ensure that after my departure, you will be able to recall these things at all times. [16] For we did not follow cleverly devised fables when we made known to you the power and coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, but we were eyewitnesses of His majesty. [17] For He received honor and glory from God the Father when the voice came to Him from the Majestic Glory, saying, "This is My beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased." [18] And we ourselves heard this voice from heaven when we were with Him on the holy mountain. [19] We also have the word of the prophets as confirmed beyond doubt. And you will do well to pay attention to it, as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star rises in your hearts. [20] Above all, you must understand that no prophecy of Scripture comes from one's own interpretation. [21] For no such prophecy was ever brought forth by the will of man, but men spoke from God as they were carried along by the Holy Spirit.

2 Now there were also false prophets among the people, just as there will be false teachers among you. They will secretly introduce destructive heresies, even denying the Master who bought them—bringing swift destruction on themselves. [2] Many will follow in their depravity, and because of them the way of truth will be defamed. [3] In their greed, these false teachers will exploit you with deceptive words. The longstanding verdict against them remains in force, and their destruction does not sleep. [4] For if God did not spare the angels when they sinned, but cast them deep into hell, placing them in chains of darkness to be held for judgment; [5] if He did not spare the ancient world when He brought the flood on its ungodly people, but preserved Noah, a preacher of righteousness, among the eight; [6] if He condemned the cities of Sodom and Gomorrah to destruction, reducing them to ashes as an example of what is coming on the ungodly; [7] and if He rescued Lot, a righteous man distressed by the depraved conduct of the lawless [8] (for that righteous man, living among them day after day, was tormented in his righteous soul by the lawless deeds he saw and heard)— [9] if all this is so, then the Lord knows how to rescue the godly from trials and to hold the unrighteous for punishment on the day of judgment. [10] Such punishment is specially reserved for those who indulge the corrupt desires of the flesh and despise authority. Bold and self-willed, they are unafraid to slander glorious beings. [11] Yet not even angels, though greater in strength and power, dare to bring such slanderous charges against them before the Lord.

[12] These men are like irrational animals, creatures of instinct, born to be captured and destroyed. They blaspheme in matters they do not understand, and like such creatures, they too will be destroyed. [13] The harm they will suffer is the wages of their wickedness. They consider it a pleasure to carouse in broad daylight. They are blots and blemishes, reveling in their deception as they feast with you.

[14] Their eyes are full of adultery; their desire for sin is never satisfied; they seduce the unstable. They are accursed children with hearts trained in greed. [15] They have left the straight way and wandered off to follow the way of Balaam son of Beor, who loved the wages of wickedness. [16] But he was rebuked for his transgression by a donkey, otherwise without speech, that spoke with a man's voice and restrained the prophet's madness. [17] These men are springs without water and mists driven by a storm. Blackest darkness is reserved for them. [18] With lofty but empty words, they appeal to the sensual passions of the flesh and entice those who are just escaping from others who live in error. [19] They promise them freedom, while they themselves are slaves to depravity. For a man is a slave to whatever has mastered him. [20] If indeed they have escaped the corruption of the world through the knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ, only to be entangled and overcome by it again, their final condition is worse than it was at first. [21] It would have been better for them not to have known the way of righteousness than to have known it and then to turn away from the holy commandment passed on to them. [22] Of them the proverbs are true: "A dog returns to its vomit," and, "A sow that is washed goes back to her wallowing in the mud."

3 Beloved, this is now my second letter to you. Both of them are reminders to stir you to wholesome thinking [2] by recalling what was foretold by the holy prophets and commanded by our Lord and Savior through your apostles. [3] Most importantly, you must understand that in the last days scoffers will come, scoffing and following their own evil desires. [4] "Where is the promise of His coming?" they will ask. "Ever since our fathers fell asleep, everything continues as it has from the beginning of creation." [5] But they deliberately overlook the fact that long ago by God's word the heavens existed and the earth was formed out of water and by water, [6] through which the world of that time perished in the flood. [7] And by that same word, the present heavens and earth are reserved for fire, being kept for the day of judgment and destruction of ungodly men. [8] Beloved, do not let this one thing escape your notice: With the Lord a day is like a thousand years, and a thousand years are like a day.

[9] The Lord is not slow in keeping His promise as some understand slowness, but is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish but everyone to come to repentance. [10] But the Day of the Lord will come like a thief. The heavens will disappear with a roar, the elements will be destroyed by fire, and the earth and its works will be laid bare. [11] Since everything will be destroyed in this way, what kind of people ought you to be? You ought to conduct yourselves in holiness and godliness [12] as you anticipate and hasten the coming of the day of God, when the heavens will be destroyed by fire and the elements will melt in the heat. [13] But in keeping with God's promise, we are looking forward to a new heaven and a new earth, where righteousness dwells. [14] Therefore, beloved, as you anticipate these things, make every effort to be found at peace—spotless and blameless in His sight. [15] Consider also that our Lord's patience brings salvation, just as our beloved brother Paul

also wrote you with the wisdom God gave him. [16] He writes this way in all his letters, speaking in them about such matters. Some parts of his letters are hard to understand, which ignorant and unstable people distort, as they do the rest of the Scriptures, to their own destruction. [17] Therefore, beloved, since you already know these things, be on your guard so that you will not be carried away by the error of the lawless and fall from your secure standing. [18] But grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. To Him be the glory both now and to the day of eternity. Amen.

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